

AP Music Theory: The Complete Exam Guide

All 8 units explained, aural and written questions, dictation and part-writing playbooks, sight-singing tips, and 10 hard practice questions.

Hi, I'm **Pigo!** I'll drop tips all through this guide.



~2:40

hours total,
with listening sections

75+9

multiple-choice +
free-response tasks

10%

of your score is
sight-singing

59–61%

scored 3 or higher
in recent years

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01

THE EXAM AT A GLANCE

Listening, writing & singing

Your AP score (1–5) combines multiple choice, written free response and two recorded sight-singing melodies. More than half of the exam involves listening to music.

45%

Multiple choice · 75 questions

45%

Written free response · 7 tasks

10%

Sight-singi...

Exam structure

Section	Weight & timing	What you do
I · Multiple choice	45% of score ~80 minutes 75 questions	About 41–43 aural questions on recorded music (~45 min) and 32–34 non-aural questions on printed scores (35 min).
IIA · Written free response	45% of score 7 tasks	2 melodic dictations · 2 harmonic dictations · 1 figured-bass part-writing · 1 Roman-numeral part-writing · 1 melody harmonization.
IIB · Sight-singing	10% of score 2 melodies	Sing two short diatonic melodies (4–8 measures). You get 75 seconds to practice and 30 seconds to perform each one, recorded.

AUDIO + PAPER

Listen carefully, write by hand

Recorded music is played during the exam, and you write notation by hand. Practice **dictation with a timer** and the exact number of playings used on the exam.

COMMON-PRACTICE STYLE

The rules of four-part harmony

Part-writing follows **18th-century voice-leading rules**: avoid parallel fifths and octaves, resolve leading tones, and keep voices in range.

How to use this guide

Just starting?

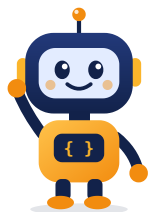
Read pages 2–6, then follow the roadmap on page 8 month by month.

Mid-year?

Check the traps on page 7 and drill the free-response playbook on page 6.

Exam in weeks?

Take the 10 questions on page 9 in 12 minutes, then use the final-four-weeks plan.



Pigo's tip: Ear training is a **daily habit**, not a cram topic. Ten minutes of interval and chord drills every day beats two hours on a weekend.

SECTION I

02 The multiple-choice section

75 questions in about 80 minutes, split between listening to recorded music and reading printed scores.

~42

aural questions with recorded music

~33

non-aural questions on printed scores

45%

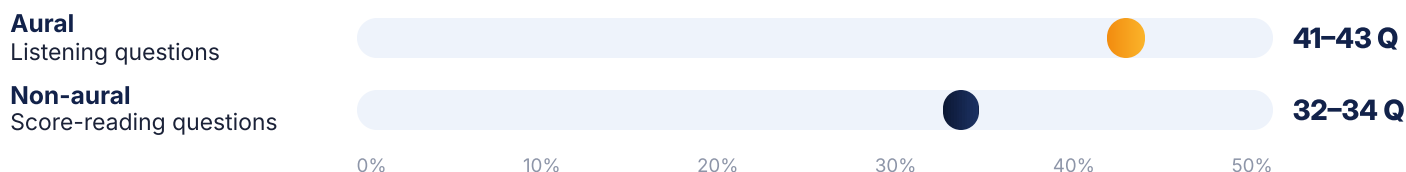
of your total AP score

0

points lost for a wrong answer, so never leave one blank

How the questions are split

College Board doesn't publish unit weights for Music Theory. Bars show the number of questions of each type.

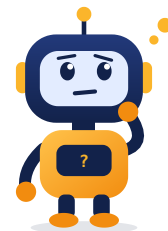


What this means for your study time: More than half of the multiple-choice questions are aural. Strong ear training (intervals, chord qualities, cadences) is the biggest single lever on your score.

Strategies that work on this section

- Listen for the **bass line first** when identifying chords and cadences.
- Sing the tonic in your head** before every aural question.
- Know your cadences:** authentic, plagal, half and deceptive.
- For score questions,** check the key signature and look for accidentals that signal modulation or secondary dominants.
- Count intervals carefully:** size first, then quality.
- Never leave a blank.** There is no penalty for guessing.

Aural questions can't be replayed on demand, so **decide on the first or second hearing** and move on.



03 WHAT THE COURSE COVERS

The 8 units, in plain English

The course builds from fundamentals to harmony and form.

UNIT

1

Music Fundamentals I

Pitch, major scales, rhythm, meter

Be ready to: read treble, bass, alto and tenor clefs; write major scales and key signatures; identify simple and compound meter.

UNIT

2

Music Fundamentals II

Minor scales, melody, timbre, texture

Be ready to: write the three forms of minor scales; identify intervals; describe melody, timbre and texture.

UNIT

3

Music Fundamentals III

Triads and seventh chords

Be ready to: spell and identify triads and seventh chords in all inversions; use Roman and figured-bass symbols.

UNIT

4

Harmony & Voice Leading I

Chord function, cadence, phrase

Be ready to: identify tonic and dominant function; name cadence types; write four-part harmony with correct voice leading.

UNIT

5

Harmony & Voice Leading II

Progressions and predominant function

Be ready to: use predominant chords; follow common progressions; avoid parallel fifths and octaves.

UNIT

6

Harmony & Voice Leading III

Embellishments, motives, devices

Be ready to: identify non-chord tones; use cadential 6/4 chords; recognize motivic development and sequences.

UNIT

7

Harmony & Voice Leading IV

Secondary function

Be ready to: spell and resolve secondary dominants and leading-tone chords; identify tonicization.

UNIT

8

Modes & Form

Modes, phrase structure, form

Be ready to: identify modes; describe phrase relationships (periods); recognize binary, ternary and other forms.

SECTION II

04 The free-response tasks

Seven written tasks and two sung melodies. Each task type is the same every year, so you can practice each one on purpose.

Melodic ×2

Harmonic ×2

Part-writing ×2

Harmonize

Sing ×2

Written free response 45% · sight-singing 10%

MD

Melodic dictation

2 tasks

Notate a melody played several times, given the key, meter and first note.

Write the rhythm first, then the scale degrees.

HD

Harmonic dictation

2 tasks

Notate the soprano and bass lines and give Roman numerals for a short progression.

Bass line and cadence first; they anchor everything else.

PW

Part-writing

Figured bass + Roman numerals

Write four-part harmony from a figured bass or a Roman-numeral progression, following voice-leading rules.

Check for parallels and resolve the leading tone up.

HM

Melody harmonization

1 task

Choose chords to harmonize a given melody, with a bass line and Roman numerals, ending with an appropriate cadence.

Plan the cadence before choosing the opening chords.

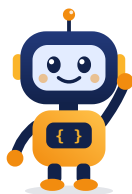
♦ Sight-singing: your 105 seconds per melody

Find tonic
10 s

Practice
65 s

Perform
30 s

You may sing aloud during the 75-second preparation. Keep a steady tempo when you perform; rhythm counts as much as pitch.



In sight-singing, **keep going** after a mistake. Stopping costs more than a wrong note.

05 FREE-RESPONSE PLAYBOOK Anatomy of clean part-writing

Part-writing points come from following voice-leading rules. Here is a short Roman-numeral task with a checklist answer.

PRACTICE TASK • WRITTEN BY ACT SAT GO

Practice task (Roman-numeral part-writing style): In C major, realize the progression **I – IV – V – I** in four parts (soprano, alto, tenor, bass), all chords in root position. Avoid parallel fifths and octaves and resolve tendency tones correctly.

One correct realization (S / A / T / B)

- ① **I:** E5 / C5 / G4 / C3 — bass C; root doubled; all chord tones present.
- ② **IV:** F5 / C5 / A4 / F3 — keep common tone C in the alto; upper voices move by step.
- ③ **V:** D5 / B4 / G4 / G3 — bass moves F→G; upper voices move in contrary motion to the bass, avoiding parallels.
- ④ **I:** E5 / C5 / G4 / C3 — leading tone B resolves up to C; authentic cadence.

- ① **Spacing:** adjacent upper voices within an octave.
- ② **Common tones** held when possible.
- ③ **Contrary motion** from IV to V avoids parallel fifths and octaves.
- ④ **Leading tone resolves up** to the tonic at the cadence.

◆ Five habits for every written task

- 1** Write the bass line and cadence first.
- 2** Check every pair of voices for parallel 5ths and 8ves.
- 3** Resolve the leading tone and chordal sevenths.
- 4** Keep each voice within its range.
- 5** Stuck in dictation? Notate rhythm; it still earns credit.

06 LEARN FROM OTHERS

10 traps that cost points

Meet **Glitch**. He lives in these ten mistakes. Squash each one before May.

Parallel fifths **sound great!** (Not in this style.)



01 Parallel 5ths and 8ves

Two voices moving in parallel perfect fifths or octaves is the most common part-writing error.

02 Unresolved leading tone

In an outer voice, the leading tone should resolve up to tonic at a cadence.

03 Doubling the leading tone

Never double the leading tone; it creates parallel octaves when both resolve.

04 Voice crossing and spacing

Keep voices in order (S above A above T) and adjacent upper voices within an octave.

05 Wrong minor-key harmony

In minor, raise the leading tone in V and vii°, using harmonic minor.

06 Interval quality

Count size first, then check quality: major, minor, perfect, augmented or diminished.

07 Mixing up cadences

V–I authentic; IV–I plagal; ends on V half; V–vi deceptive.

08 Rhythm last in dictation

Getting the rhythm right first anchors the pitches and earns points on its own.

09 Stopping when sight-singing

Keep a steady beat and recover. Stopping or restarting costs points.

10 Ignoring the key signature

Check the key before every score question; accidentals often signal secondary chords.

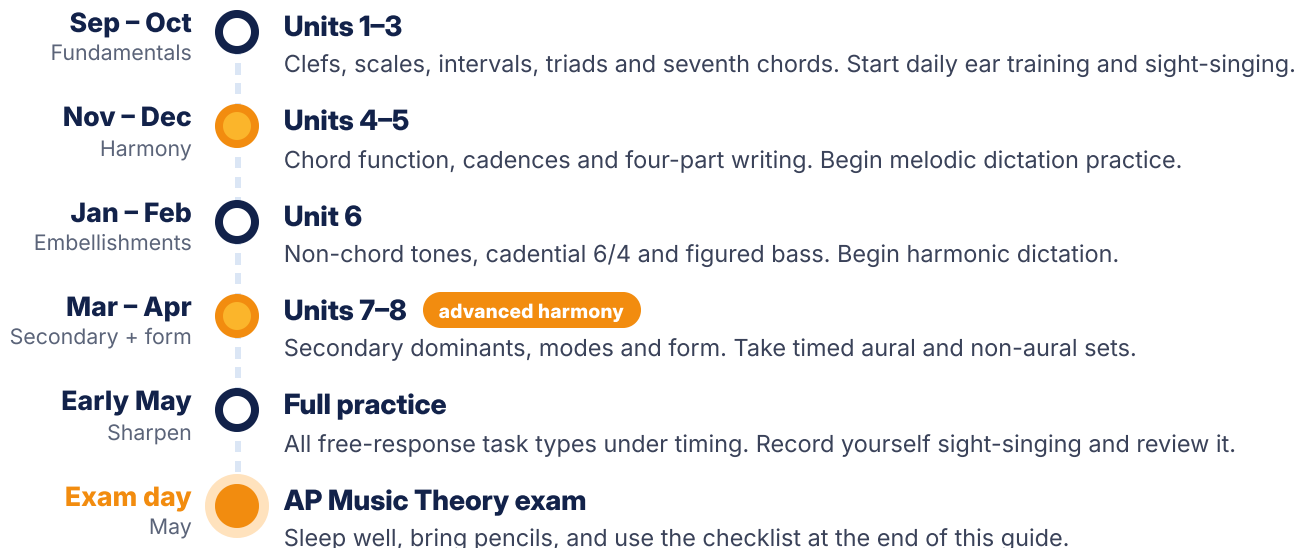
Quick self-check: in G major, what is the secondary dominant V/V, and where does it resolve? (D major is V; its V is A major, A–C#–E, resolving to D.)



PLAN YOUR YEAR

Your study roadmap to May

A steady plan beats a last-minute rush. Do ten minutes of ear training and one sight-singing melody every day.



• The final four weeks

Week	Focus	Target
4 weeks out	Diagnose: one aural set, one dictation of each type	List your weakest task type
3 weeks out	Daily dictation and part-writing drills	No parallels in any exercise
2 weeks out	Full practice exam with audio	Finish every section on time
Final week	Light review: cadences, voice-leading rules, sight-singing	Rest the night before

08 TEST YOURSELF

10 practice questions

Original non-aural questions written by ACT SAT GO in the style of the exam, pitched at the harder end. Give yourself **12 minutes**, then check page 10.

1 INTERVALS

What is the interval from F# up to D?

- A Major 6th
- B Augmented 5th
- C Diminished 7th
- D Minor 6th

2 CHORDS

The notes B $\flat$ –D–F–A $\flat$ form which seventh chord?

- A Major seventh
- B Minor seventh
- C Dominant seventh
- D Half-diminished seventh

3 KEYS

Which key signature has four sharps?

- A A major / F# minor
- B E major / C# minor
- C B major / G# minor
- D D major / B minor

4 FIGURED BASS

A chord labeled V⁶₅ has which chord member in the bass?

- A Third
- B Root
- C Fifth
- D Seventh

5 CADENCES

A phrase ends with the progression V – vi. This cadence is called:

- A Authentic
- B Plagal
- C Deceptive
- D Half

6 SECONDARY FUNCTION

In D major, which chord is V/V?

- A E major
- B A major
- C B minor
- D G major

7 VOICE LEADING

In four-part writing, which situation is **not** acceptable in common-practice style?

- A Soprano and bass moving in contrary motion
- B Holding a common tone in the alto
- C Doubling the root of a root-position triad
- D Tenor and bass moving in parallel perfect fifths

8 MINOR KEYS

In A minor, the dominant chord in harmonic minor is:

- A E minor
- B E major
- C G major
- D C major

9 NON-CHORD TONES

A note approached by step and left by leap in the opposite direction is:

- A a passing tone
- B a neighbor tone
- C an escape tone
- D a suspension

10 METER

A piece in 6/8 time is best described as:

- A simple duple
- B compound duple
- C simple triple
- D compound triple

09

CHECK YOUR WORK

Answer key & explanations

Read every explanation, even for questions you got right. Each one points to a pattern that keeps coming back on the exam.

#	Answer	Why
1	D • Minor 6th	F to D is a 6th (F G A B C D). F to D would be a major 6th; raising F to F# shrinks it by a half step: minor 6th.
2	C • Dominant seventh	B $\flat$ -D-F is a major triad; A $\flat$ is a minor seventh above B $\flat$. Major triad + minor 7th = dominant seventh.
3	B • E major / C# minor	The order of sharps is F# C# G# D#; four sharps is E major, whose relative minor is C# minor.
4	A • Third	Seventh-chord inversions: 7 = root, 6/5 = first inversion (third in bass), 4/3 = fifth, 4/2 = seventh.
5	C • Deceptive	V moving to vi instead of I "deceives" the ear: a deceptive cadence.
6	A • E major	V in D major is A major. V of A is E major (E-G#-B), which tonicizes A.
7	D	Parallel perfect fifths (and octaves) between any two voices are avoided in common-practice voice leading.
8	B • E major	Harmonic minor raises the 7th scale degree (G to G#), making the dominant chord E-G#-B: major.
9	C	An escape tone is approached by step and left by leap in the opposite direction.
10	B • compound duple	6/8 has two main beats, each divided into three eighth notes: compound duple.

9–10

Strong. Move on to full timed free-response practice.

6–8

On track. Revisit the unit behind every miss on page 4.

0–5

Build foundations now. Drill intervals, key signatures and chord spelling daily.

10 KNOW THE TARGET

How students score

In recent years, about 59–61% of students earned a 3 or higher on AP Music Theory, and about 18–19% earned a 5. Steady preparation is what moves a score up a full point.

59–61%

of students earned a 3 or higher in recent years

18–19%

earned the top score of 5 in recent years

3+

is the score many colleges accept for credit or placement

What each AP score means

5

Extremely well qualified

4

Very well qualified

3

Qualified

2

Possibly qualified

1

No recommendation

Ranges reflect recent College Board score distributions and shift a little each year. Credit and placement policies vary by college, so check each college's AP policy.

Exam-day checklist

- ☐ Two **No. 2 pencils** and a dark-ink pen
- ☐ Admission ticket and photo ID, as your school requires
- ☐ Confirm your **exam day and start time** in May with your AP coordinator
- ☐ A watch without an alarm or internet connection, if allowed
- ☐ Practice **dictation** with the same number of playings as the exam
- ☐ Answer **every** multiple-choice question. Wrong answers don't lose points
- ☐ Warm up your voice before the **sight-singing** section
- ☐ Review voice-leading rules and cadence types the night before

In the free-response tasks: notate rhythm first in dictation, check every voice pair for parallels, resolve leading tones and sevenths, and keep a steady tempo when sight-singing.



ACT SAT GO • 1-ON-1 AP TUTORING

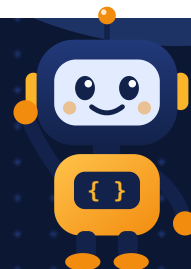
Aiming for a 5? Get a personal AP Music Theory plan.

Book a free diagnostic lesson. We'll find your weakest units, review your practice responses, and give you a week-by-week plan to exam day in May.

Book a free diagnostic lesson →



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Theory & ear-training tutoring

Live 1-on-1 sessions on all eight units, with interval, chord and cadence drills.

Dictation & part-writing coaching

Practice every free-response task type and get feedback on voice leading and notation.

Sight-singing practice

Timed sight-singing sessions with feedback on pitch, rhythm and recovery.

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